CONCLUSION

The role of Myanmar's legislature in responding to conflicts was similar to its counterparts elsewhere in some aspects, but different in several ways. While legislatures are usually equipped with similar legislative tools of representation, executive oversight and lawmaking mechanisms, their institutional characteristics greatly shape the way they use these instruments. In Myanmar's case, lawmakers were reluctant to use their representative functions because these were new to them and institutionally not so favourable. But the Hluttaw's advantage came from its non-partisan approach, speaking with one voice and controlling itself so as not to be involved in exacerbating conflicts.

The Hluttaw has been hailed as a symbol of Myanmar's transition for its autonomy, inclusiveness, and its oversight of the executive. Haunted by the horrible memories of factionalism in the post-independence parliamentary system, the Hluttaw has tried to take a non-partisan approach as much as possible. This approach, combined with the socialist parliamentary style of the legislature questioning the executive, led the whole house to become an opposition to the executive. This made the house strong when encountering the executive, as in the case of the CTU and oversight of the executive.

All these characteristics of the legislature can be attributed to power entrusted to the reform-minded leaders of the legislature: the two speakers. The important role of the speakers affirmed the old tradition of Myanmar society where agency is more important than the institution. Because they had extraordinary power to significantly influence the legislature, they were able to operate skilfully. These institutional practices would no doubt be passed on to the next Hluttaw after the 2015 election. The new political arrangement would be a lot different than the first Hluttaw, as the NLD becomes the ruling party. Whether the new Hluttaw will try to inherit or reject institutional practices from its predecessor, such as the non-partisan nature of the Hluttaw, remains to be seen. Nonetheless, Myanmar's first legislature should be credited for its attempt to mediate conflicts regardless of its institutional constraints and transitional challenges.